

2 Subject content and assessment information

This qualification will support students in forming personal and meaningful relationships with music through the development of musical knowledge, understanding and skills, including performing, composing and appraising. Students will be encouraged to engage critically and creatively with a wide range of music and musical contexts, develop an understanding of the place of music in different cultures and contexts, and reflect on how music is used in the expression of personal and collective identities.

This qualification will also allow students to develop particular strengths and interests, encourage lifelong learning and provide access to higher education and university degree courses in music and music-related subjects, as well as music-related and other careers.

Qualification aims and objectives

The aims and objectives of this qualification are to enable students to:

- actively engage in the process of music study
- develop performing skills to demonstrate an understanding of musical elements, style, sense of continuity, interpretation and expression
- develop composing skills to demonstrate the manipulation of musical ideas and the use of musical devices and conventions
- recognise the interdependence of musical knowledge, understanding and skills, and make links between the integrated activities of performing, composing and appraising underpinned by attentive listening
- broaden musical experience and interests, develop imagination and foster creativity
- develop and extend the knowledge, understanding and skills needed to communicate effectively as musicians
- develop knowledge and understanding of a variety of instruments and styles, and of relevant approaches to both performing and composing
- develop awareness of music technologies and their use in the creation and presentation of music
- appraise contrasting genres, styles and traditions of music, and develop understanding of musical contexts and a coherent awareness of musical chronology

- develop as effective, independent learners and as critical and reflective thinkers with enquiring minds
- reflect critically and make personal judgements on their own and others' music
- engage with, and extend appreciation of, the diverse heritage of music in order to promote personal, social, intellectual and cultural development.

Component 1: Performing

Overview

The purpose of this component is to assess students' performing skills in a solo and/or ensemble context. They should be given the opportunity to rehearse and refine performances on their chosen instrument or voice, developing technical control, expression and interpretative skills.

This component will encourage students to develop creative thinking, aesthetic sensitivity, critical awareness, self-confidence, self-motivation and their own musical interests and skills, including the ability to make music individually and/or in groups, and perform with control, using phrasing and dynamics appropriate to their chosen styles and moods of music.

Students must perform:

- a minimum of one piece, performed live and uninterrupted as a recital
- performances can be solo, as part of an ensemble, improvisation, realisation using music technology, or a combination of these
- total performance time across the recital must be a minimum of eight minutes of music.

Timing does not include the time taken to tune the instrument or any gaps between pieces.

Content

The following content explains what should be learned for each type of performance and then explains the possible approaches to performing in general that can be applied to each student's performance as desired and appropriate.

Students will be required to demonstrate the ability to:

- make use of musical elements, techniques and resources to interpret and communicate musical ideas with technical and expressive control and an understanding of style and context. This must be achieved by one or more of the following means: playing or singing solo or in ensemble, improvising, or realising music using music technology
- perform music with control and continuity, using appropriate tempi, showing critical understanding of the music chosen
- perform fluently, showing critical understanding of the overall shape, direction and style of the music chosen.

Students should take into account the effect of the purpose and intention of their piece of music when performing. They must also consider the effect of audience, time and place when they perform their pieces.

Students should listen to how established performers communicate. They should appraise their own use of articulation, phrasing and dynamics in the light of these performances and reflect this when shaping their interpretation of their chosen music. Students should know and understand the appropriate musical vocabulary and terminology related to their performances.

Students will be assessed on their skills demonstrated during a live, unedited, uninterrupted performance. Recordings of performances (using any instruments and/or technology) may not be edited afterwards.

For this component, students can use any instrument for their solo and/or ensemble pieces, including those that make use of music technology (e.g. electric guitar).

For some performance options, students may record their own backing track or accompaniment. However, students will only be assessed on their final live performance.

Students can take one or more of the following approaches to their performance, as appropriate:

Solo performance

A solo performance is considered to be a piece in which the student's part plays a significant or leading role. The performance may be on any instrument or voice in any style or genre.

Music that was written with an accompaniment must be performed with that accompaniment. The accompaniment should not be altered to double the solo line. The usual accompaniment for a solo performance will be by one other performer on a contrasting instrument. For instance, a singer, flautist or trombonist may be accompanied by a pianist, or a jazz saxophonist may be accompanied by a double bass player. However, students are able to perform with a larger ensemble where there is a clear solo part throughout and the music was originally written for these forces.

Performances accompanied by backing tracks are acceptable but the part to be assessed must not be audible as part of the backing track.

Ensemble performance

An ensemble performance must consist of two or more people performing undoubled, simultaneously sounding, independent parts, with or without additional backing or accompaniment as appropriate. The performance may be on any instrument or voice in any style or genre.

Students who choose to perform in an ensemble should, in addition to accuracy and other essentials of effective performance, pay attention to balance and the demands of other parts.

Students are assessed on the whole of the ensemble performance, even points at which the individual being assessed is not playing/singing themselves. Therefore students should be encouraged to understand how to interact with and react to their other ensemble performers.

Ensemble performances accompanied by backing tracks are acceptable as long as there are at least two live performers and the part to be assessed is not audible as part of the backing track.

Improvisation

Students who choose to improvise should learn to play the music accurately and go on to exploit and develop its potential. They should pay attention to intonation, tuning, coherence and to structure generally. They should work on their instrumental tone and technique and demonstrate their ability to shape the music effectively. They should also recognise the importance of fluency and ensure that the overall outcome is effective in terms of communication, interpretation and style, for example with jazz music.

Realisation using music technology

Students may perform using music technology. Music technology may involve the use of synthesisers, virtual instruments and amplified instruments, such as guitars using pedals (including loop pedals), audio samples, and other processors.

Students will be assessed on their ability to perform a live solo line, which may (or may not) include playing over a pre-recorded/sequenced backing track (which might have been created by the student themselves). This pre-recorded/sequenced backing track is not assessed.

Examples of how to play the live solo line might include electric guitar or synthesiser, with live use of effects and processes.

Approaches to performing

Students will need to understand the following as appropriate for their chosen performance.

- A score can mean staff notation with written instructions for the playing of a piece of music. When performing from a score, students should understand the contextual influences affecting the composition of the pieces they are performing, including the composer's intentions regarding the venue and nature of the performance, and any important cultural influences relating to the composition of the piece.
- Students should learn the importance of attention to intonation, tuning and accuracy of pitch and rhythm when performing from a score. They should work on their instrumental tone and technique, and ensure that they observe all performance directions for phrasing, articulation, dynamics and tempo. They should also recognise the importance of fluency and ensure that the overall outcome is effective in terms of communication, interpretation and style.
- For rapping (similar to vocal performances) students should demonstrate clarity of diction, secure breath control, tonal contrast and some extended vocal techniques. For beatboxing, students choosing to beatbox should create a variety of contrasting timbres and demonstrate effective control of rhythm.
- Students may choose to perform by the oral tradition that does not fall under solo improvisation or traditional performances. In this context, oral tradition means material and tradition transmitted orally from one generation to another, often taking the form of folktales, ballads, songs or chants.
- Students may perform their own compositions when supported by a score with sufficient performance detail to assess accuracy of pitch and rhythm.

Musical elements

Depending on the choice of instrument(s) and/or voice(s), and the piece of music performed, the student should use the appropriate musical elements in their performance.

The musical elements are listed below:

- Organisation of pitch
- Tonality
- Structure
- Sonority
- Texture
- Tempo, metre and rhythm
- Dynamics.

Musical contexts

Students should take into account the effect of the purpose and intention of their piece of music, and the effect of audience, time and place when performing their pieces. Students should perform their music with control, expressing the music as appropriate to its style and mood. Students should take into account how music is created, developed and performed in different historical, social and cultural contexts, as well as how music from different historical, social and cultural contexts has changed over time.

Musical language

Depending on the choice of instrument(s) and/or voice(s), and the piece of music, the student should be able to read and play music using the appropriate musical language.

Types of musical language are listed below:

- reading and writing of staff notation
- chords and associated chord symbols, and standard harmonic progressions
- musical vocabulary and terminology related to the areas of study.

Assessment information

- First assessment: 2018.
- This component consists of 60 marks.
- Students must perform at least one piece of music as a recital, in front of a live audience of at least two people
- The performance must have a total duration of at least eight minutes.
- For performances that **do not** meet the total minimum time requirement, the performance mark will be reduced proportionally according to how many seconds the performance is less than eight minutes. Please see *Appendix 10: Mark penalty tables for submissions not meeting the minimum assessment time*.
- Performances may use any instrument or voice.
- Performances can be solo, as part of an ensemble, improvisation, realisation using music technology, or a combination of these.
- The final performance and recording will be carried out after 1 March and all materials for assessment submitted to arrive by 15 May in the year of certification.
- Centres must ensure that the performances submitted are valid for the series in which they are submitted.

Task setting

Students must select the piece(s) of music that they will perform during the assessment following discussion with the centre delivering the assessment.

Teachers should ensure that the performances are relevant and appropriate to the student's course of learning. Students should have the opportunity to choose sources/interpretations, as appropriate.

Each performance should be of sufficient length and complexity to give the performer adequate opportunity to demonstrate their abilities. The teacher should ensure that the level of demand is appropriate to allow the student to present a personal and meaningful response.

Teachers may help students to understand rubrics, assessment criteria and controls. Teachers may help students with their performance choices, styles and techniques. Any additional feedback must be recorded on the Performance Authentication Sheet, please see *Appendix 1*.

If the student accompanies themselves, for example by singing and playing an instrument, then the role to be assessed should be agreed beforehand between the teacher and student.

Task taking

The final, recorded performance must take place in front of a live audience of at least two people. It must be recorded after 1 March and all materials for assessment submitted to arrive by 15 May in the year of certification.

Students must perform continuously and not piece together their submissions from a number of recorded performances. However, their whole submission may be re-performed and re-recorded before submission.

If a student wishes to perform for longer than eight minutes, to demonstrate their performance skills more fully, they may do so. Performances should be of sufficient length and complexity to allow students adequate opportunity to showcase their abilities. However, a guided maximum of 12 minutes is recommended.

Submissions over the guided maximum time for combined compositions will still be marked. This is guidance for teachers to avoid students submitting excessively long submissions which may be self-penalising.

The performance must last a minimum duration of eight minutes.

The minimum of eight minutes relates to the length of the student's performance across the piece(s). It does not include pauses between pieces or sections of music where the student is not performing.

Performance assessment

Authenticity

Students' performances must be recorded live, unedited, without interruptions and without the teacher giving guidance. If students wish to re-record a performance before submission, they must re-record the whole recital performance, and not just part of it. The live performance must be in front of an audience of at least two people, of which one must be the teacher.

Resources

Students must have equal access to IT resources. Students should have access to a range of resources/texts to enable them to make choices as required for their tasks.

Items for submission for assessment

1. Recording

Centres must submit a complete and unedited recording of the live performance via the online submission platform Learner Work Transfer (LWT). The work of each student should be a separate track, individually labelled with their centre number, candidate number and title.

2. Score

Where a written score or lead sheet exists, this must be submitted with the recording of the performance. If a piece has been learnt aurally, a professional reference recording may be submitted in addition.

If a written score or lead sheet does not exist, then appropriate reference material must be submitted (a professional reference recording, written commentary, and stimulus for improvised performances, track sheets, tables or diagrams).

The notated music must be provided for all performances from a score. This music must contain all the information necessary to assess the accuracy of the performance, for example, a guitar tab score with no indication of rhythm is unacceptable: scores should use conventional staff notation. Deviations from the score in jazz/rock and musical theatre numbers will generally be accepted where they are considered to be stylistically convincing.

For performances from a score/lead sheet, photocopies of the music must be submitted with the recording. Only the part performed needs to be submitted, for example just the clarinet part in a piece for clarinet with piano accompaniment. Original copies should not be supplied. Photocopies will be destroyed by Pearson at the end of the examination period.

For realising music using music technology, a detailed commentary and/or a professional reference recording must be submitted alongside a written score/lead sheet (if one exists). For sequenced performances, only the recording of the live track will be assessed. This track must be indicated when submitting.

These scores/lead sheets and/or reference materials should include as much detail as possible to allow the examiner to make a fair and accurate judgement on the quality and accuracy of the performance. The scores/lead sheets and/or reference materials are not assessed and receive no marks.

Performances that are not accompanied by acceptable scores/lead sheets/reference materials cannot be assessed.

3. Performance Authentication Sheet

The Performance Authentication Sheet (PAS) must be completed by the teacher, and signed by the student and teacher, authenticating that the work is the student's own. Please see *Appendix 1*.

4. Submissions not meeting minimum time requirement

The performance time must be at least eight minutes.

Students submitting performances of less than eight minutes in length will be marked against the assessment criteria on the following pages. The performance mark will then be reduced proportionally according to how many seconds the performance time is less than eight minutes. Please see *Appendix 10: Mark penalty tables for submissions not meeting the minimum assessment time*.

Gaps between pieces and tuning **do not** count towards the performance time.

If students wish to re-record a performance before submission, they must re-record the whole performance (either solo or ensemble), and not just part of it. The teacher must be present during the recordings.

Assessment criteria

Performance recitals will be externally assessed for all students. All assessment materials must be sent to the examiner to arrive by 15 May in the year of certification.

There are 60 marks available for this assessment. Performances will be assessed as a whole, regardless of the number of pieces which make up the recital.

Performances will be marked using the three assessment criteria grids on the following pages to give a mark out of 48. There are also a further twelve marks available for the difficulty of the piece (totalling 60 marks). Information on difficulty levels can be found on pages 29–31.

These criteria have been developed to assess students' skills in technique, accuracy and fluency, and expressive control, style and context. All performances are able to be assessed using the criteria on the following pages, including realising music using technology. For ensemble performances, students are to be assessed on their role in the whole performances (even during periods when they themselves are not actually playing/singing). Some grids contain additional information in italics for use with ensemble and/or improvised performances.

Performance is assessed against AO1: Interpret musical ideas through performing, with technical and expressive control and an understanding of style and context.

- Performance assessment grid 1: Technical control – Technique assesses the students' technical control of the instrument.
- Performance assessment grid 2: Technical control (Accuracy) and Expressive control (Fluency) assesses the students' ability to use technical control to play the pieces accurately, and their ability to use expressive control to play the pieces fluently.
- Performance assessment grid 3: Expressive control, style and context assesses the students' ability to communicate through the use of musical elements and interpret ideas with expressive control and an understanding of style and context.

Performance assessment grid 1: Technical control – Technique

These marks are awarded for the interpretation of musical ideas with technical control. In this grid, this is defined as control of the instrument, for example:

- coordination between the hands, or of the bow/fingers
- breath control
- diction
- pedalling
- registration
- intonation
- tone quality
- use of filters and effects
- control of musical sources.

This will include making use of musical elements as appropriate to the requirements of the instrument(s) and piece performed. For ensemble performances, this grid assesses only the student's individual control of their instrument.

Level	Mark	Technical control – technique (AO1)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1 Poor technique	1–2	• The performance demonstrates poor technical control, as heard in poor coordination, breath control, diction and/or pedalling. • The demands of the music are beyond the current ability of the performer. • The handling of sonority is poor, as heard in dull, thin, coarse tone quality across the whole range and/or poor intonation throughout and/or poor use of filters and effects throughout.
Level 2 Limited technique	3–5	• The performance demonstrates limited technical control, as heard in limited coordination, breath control, diction and/or pedalling. • There are several places where the demands of the music are beyond the current ability of the performer. • The handling of sonority is limited as heard in several passages where tone is less than acceptable (dull, coarse, thin, uneven) and/or several passages of poor intonation and/or limited use of filters and effects throughout.
Level 3 Basic technique	6–8	• The performance demonstrates basic technical control of the instrument, as heard in basic coordination, breath control, diction and/or pedalling. • There are a few places where the demands of the music are beyond the current ability of the performer. • The handling of sonority is basic as heard in tone quality that is generally acceptable and/or several individual notes out of tune and/or basic use of filters and effects throughout.

Level	Mark	Technical control – technique (AO1)
Level 4 Convincing technique	9–11	• The performance demonstrates convincing technical control of the instrument, as heard in convincing coordination, breath control, diction and/or pedalling. • There are only one or two places where the demands of the music are beyond the current ability of the performer. • The handling of sonority is convincing as heard in consistently good tone quality and awareness of tonal contrast, except at the extremities of the pitch range or at moments of technical difficulty, and/or generally good intonation with no more than a few out of tune notes and/or convincing use of filters and effects throughout.
Level 5 Assured technique	12–14	• The performance demonstrates assured technical control of the instrument, as heard in assured coordination, breath control, diction and/or pedalling. • The demands of the music are within the current ability of the performer. • The handling of sonority is assured as heard in very good tone quality across the pitch range (satisfying, interesting and even as the music demands) and/or generally convincing intonation and/or assured use of filters and effects throughout. The performance will sensitively exploit tonal contrast in places, where appropriate.
Level 6 Outstanding technique	15–16	• The performance will demonstrate complete control of the instrument. • The handling of sonority is outstanding as heard in excellent tone quality across the pitch range (exciting, vibrant, rich, resonant, sensitive and colourful, as the music demands) and/or entirely secure intonation (within only one or two out of tune notes at the lower end of the band) and/or excellent use of filters and effects throughout. The performance will sensitively exploit tonal contrast.

Performance assessment grid 2: Technical control (Accuracy) and Expressive control (Fluency)

In this grid, marks are awarded for the interpretation of musical ideas with technical control (accuracy), and the expression (fluency) of the performance, as appropriate to the chosen instrument(s) and pieces, including making use of musical elements as appropriate. The accuracy and fluency of sequenced performances will be assessed against the reference recording and any other materials provided as a score. The text in italics is to be applied to improvised and/or ensemble performances.

Level	Mark	Technical control (Accuracy) and Expressive control (Fluency) (AO1)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1 Poor accuracy and fluency	1–2	• Obtrusive errors of pitch and/or rhythm impact on many passages. • Performances at the lower end of the band are largely inaccurate, with many noticeable/obtrusive errors of pitch and/or rhythm. • Fluency is frequently compromised by breakdowns and/or omissions. • <i>Improvised performances will demonstrate little accuracy when performing the stimulus and little development of this material. The improvisation will lack coherence and contrast.</i> • <i>In ensemble performances there is little awareness of balance throughout.</i>
Level 2 Limited accuracy and fluency	3–5	• Performances in this band will have several noticeable/obtrusive errors in pitch and/or rhythm which impact on the success of the performance overall. • Fluency is compromised in several places and coherence is often lost. • <i>Improvised performances will demonstrate some accuracy when performing the stimulus, and will go on to show limited development of this stimulus. The overall improvisation will sound repetitive, predictable and/or formulaic.</i> • <i>In ensemble performances there is little awareness of balance for the majority of the piece.</i>

Level	Mark	Technical control (Accuracy) and Expressive control (Fluency) (AO1)
Level 3 Basic accuracy and fluency	6–8	- Performances in this band will have more than two noticeable/obtrusive errors or omissions, or several errors that have little or no impact on the success of the performance overall, or several errors in just one (difficult) passage. - There will be moments where coherence is lost but the performance will still be reasonably fluent for the majority of piece. <i>Improvised performances will demonstrate a mostly accurate performance of the stimulus, and will go on to show some development of this stimulus. The overall improvisation will show some attempt at creating variety but may rely heavily on repetition and will be repetitive, predictable and/or formulaic in places.</i> <i>In ensemble performances there is some awareness of balance.</i>
Level 4 Convincing accuracy and fluency	9–11	- There will be no more than one or two noticeable/obtrusive errors or omissions in pitch and/or rhythm, or a few errors that have little or no impact on the success of the performance overall. - The performance will be mostly fluent despite the occasional hesitation and/or omission. <i>Improvised performances will demonstrate a mostly accurate performance of the stimulus, and will go on to show some development of this stimulus. The overall improvisation will sound mostly coherent, well balanced and effective, if not always imaginative.</i> <i>In ensemble performances there is a good awareness of balance, with only the odd minor misjudgement.</i>

Level	Mark	Technical control (Accuracy) and Expressive control (Fluency) (AO1)
Level 5 Assured accuracy and fluency	12–14	• The performance will have a few minor errors in pitch and/or rhythm, but these errors will have no impact on the success of the performance overall. • Performances will be fluent despite the occasional very slight hesitation and/or omission. • <i>Improvised performances will demonstrate an accurate performance of the stimulus, and will go on to produce an interesting realisation of this stimulus. The overall improvisation will sound coherent, well balanced and effective, if not fully exploiting all possibilities.</i> • <i>In ensemble performances there is a good awareness of balance throughout.</i>
Level 6 Outstanding accuracy and fluency	15–16	• The performance will demonstrate entirely accurate pitch and rhythm, with only one or two insignificant errors at the lower end of the band. • The performance should be fluent and entirely free from hesitation or omission. • <i>Improvised performances will demonstrate an accurate performance of the stimulus, and will go on to produce an ambitious and creative realisation of this stimulus. The overall improvisation will sound coherent, well balanced and imaginative.</i> • <i>In ensemble performances there is an excellent awareness of balance throughout.</i>

Performance assessment grid 3: Expressive control, style and context

In this grid, marks are awarded for communicating through the use of musical elements as appropriate to the piece performed, and interpreting ideas with expressive control and an understanding of style and context as appropriate to each piece. If using pre-recorded or sequenced backing tracks, the assessment of tempo reflects how well the performer matches and responds to it. The text in italics is to be applied to improvised and/or ensemble performances as appropriate.

Level	Mark	Expressive control, style and context (AO1)
	0	No rewardable material
Level 1 Poor interpretation	1–2	Very few interpretative skills evident through: - an inconsistent tempo throughout, <i>and in ensemble performances there is evidence of difficulty in reacting and adjusting to other parts throughout.</i> (Expressive control) - little or no appropriate dynamic contrast, and little or no attention given to phrasing and articulation. (Style and context)
Level 2 Limited interpretation	3–5	An insecure interpretation through: - an inconsistent tempo for the majority of the piece, <i>and in ensemble performances there is evidence of difficulty in reacting and adjusting to the other parts for the majority of the piece.</i> (Expressive control) - limited use of dynamics, phrasing and articulation to shape the performance (Style and context) - a performance that struggles to communicate and may sound mechanical. (Style and context)
Level 3 Basic interpretation	6–8	A secure interpretation through: - several inconsistencies of tempo (perhaps around difficult passages), <i>and in ensemble performance there is occasional difficulty in reacting and adjusting to other parts.</i> (Expressive control) - some use of dynamics, phrasing and articulation to shape the performance, but several opportunities, notated or otherwise, are missed (Style and context) - some involvement with the music, but character and style are evident only intermittently. (Style and context)

Level	Mark	Expressive control, style and context (AO1)
Level 4 Convincing interpretation	9–11	A confident and engaging interpretation achieved through: - only a few minor inconsistencies of tempo, <i>and in ensemble performances there is generally good reaction and, where appropriate, adjustment to other parts, with only minor misjudgements.</i> (Expressive control) - some use of dynamics, phrasing and articulation to shape the performance, but a few opportunities, notated or otherwise, are missed (Style and context) - fairly successful communication, with one or two less-successful moments lower in the band. (Style and context)
Level 5 Assured interpretation	12–14	An exciting and communicative interpretation achieved through: - the tempo being consistent with only one or two minor inconsistencies, <i>and in ensemble performances there is a good reaction and, where appropriate, adjustment to other parts throughout.</i> (Expressive control) - the frequent use of dynamics, phrasing and articulation to shape the performance (Style and context) - characterful communication that is mostly idiomatic, and musically shaped. (Style and context)
Level 6 Outstanding interpretation	15–16	A mature, individual and imaginative interpretation achieved through: - the use of tempo that is always consistent, <i>and in ensemble performances a consistently responsive reaction and, where appropriate, adjustment to other parts is evident throughout.</i> (Expressive control) - effective communication that is idiomatic, and musically shaped, with consistent use of dynamics, phrasing and articulation to shape the performance. (Style and context)

Difficulty levels

Depending on how difficult the piece of music performed is, the marks for its difficulty should be applied using this grid. The difficulty level of selected pieces of music can be found in the *Pearson Edexcel GCSE, AS and A level Music Difficulty Levels Booklet*, on the Pearson website. These can be used as indicators of the demand of pieces of music and should inform the teacher's judgement in assessing how difficult the pieces performed by the students are.

Examiners will assess the difficulty level of each piece performed, as guided by the *Pearson Edexcel GCSE, AS and A level Music Difficulty Levels Booklet*, and apply a difficulty level to the whole performance based on an average, although taking into consideration the relative length of pieces where these lengths are unbalanced.

Once the level of difficulty of the piece(s) performed is decided, the raw mark (the total from grids 1, 2 and 3) out of 48 will then be applied to the corresponding difficulty level column. This gives the total mark for the recital, out of a maximum of